



Judy Davis, and Ridley Scott's space-age heroine Ripley in *Alien*, played by Sigourney Weaver. Women kept pushing the boundaries: Dawn Steel became one of the first women to run a Hollywood studio (Columbia Pictures) in 1987; and established scriptwriter Nancy Meyers directed *The Parent Trap* (1998), the first of her many box office hits.

Female-driven films have become increasingly successful. In 2010, Kathryn Bigelow became the first female director to win an Oscar, and Patty Jenkins' *Wonder Woman* (2017) became the highest-grossing superhero origin story of all time. In Bollywood, Vidya Balan broke the mold playing a heavily pregnant heroine in the blockbuster *Kahaani* (2012). While women's influence in film continues to grow, exemplified by writer-directors such as Sofia Coppola and Greta Gerwig, campaigning organizations such as Woman and Hollywood recognize there is still some way to go.

▲ Femme fatale

German actress Marlene Dietrich's provocative characters defied many traditional gender norms. In this still from *Blue Angel* (1930), she appears donning a tuxedo as the cabaret star Lola Lola.

KATHRYN BIGELOW WINS THE OSCAR FOR BEST DIRECTOR



PROFILES

LEADING LADIES

Alice Guy Blaché (1873-1968) was the first female film director. She began working as a secretary in Paris in 1896, and produced, directed, or supervised some 750 films before moving to New York in 1907. In 1910, she started her own production business, Solax, and went on to direct around 50 of the 325 films it produced. Blaché pioneered techniques such as the split screen and double exposure.

Edith Head (1897-1981) was a costume designer who was nominated for 34 Academy Awards (and won eight). She shaped the style of Hollywood through her work for Paramount and Universal, on films such as *Roman Holiday* (1953), *To Catch a Thief* (1955), and *The Sting* (1973). Her work helped to make style icons of Audrey Hepburn, Grace Kelly, Elizabeth Taylor, and Marlene Dietrich.

Anna May Wong (1905-1961) was Hollywood's first Chinese-American movie star. Her first leading role was in 1922 as a deserted bride in *The Toll of the Sea*, followed by the role of a slave in *The Thief of Bagdad* (1924). In the sound era, her films included *Shanghai Express* (1932). Wong's career later suffered due to the lack of roles written for Asian women.

Jane Campion (b. 1954) is a New Zealand-born screenwriter, producer, and director who became the first woman to win the Palme d'Or at Cannes for her film *The Piano* (1993). The film also won her an Oscar for best original screenplay in 1994, and she became the second woman ever to be nominated for best director for that same movie.

Zoya Akhtar (b. 1972) is one of the few female directors in Bollywood, and one of only three making blockbusters grossing over 100 crore (\$15 million). She began as an assistant director to her brother Farhan Akhtar and worked with filmmaker Mira Nair, before studying film at New York University. Akhtar's films have been credited with drawing attention to the sexism in Indian society without obscuring the Bollywood narrative.